

Civil Peace

- Chinua Achebe

- Understanding the text

* Answer the following questions.

a) Why did Jonathan think of himself as 'extraordinarily lucky'?

Ans Jonathan thought he was "extraordinarily lucky" because he and most of his family survived the Nigerian civil war. Many people lost their lives and property, but his wife and three of his four children were alive. He also found that his house in Enugu was still standing when many others were destroyed. Even his bicycle was safe, which helped him start a taxi business. He believed that staying alive was the greatest luck of all.

b) What are the 'five blessings' for which Jonathan is grateful?

Ans The "five blessings" are Jonathan himself, his wife Maria, and three of their four children who survived the Nigerian civil war. Although they lost one child, the other five family members were alive. Jonathan believes that life is more important than property or money. He thanks God again and again for saving them. Even after losing many things, he feels happy and satisfied because his

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family is safe and together.

c) Why did Jonathan mistrust the officer who wanted to take his bicycle? What does this tell you about the situation in Nigeria?

Ans Jonathan mistrusted the officer because he was unsure whether the man was a real government officer. After the war, many dishonest people pretended to be officials to steal from others. There was confusion and corruption everywhere. People could not easily trust authority. This shows that Nigeria was facing serious problems after the war. Law and order were weak and citizens had to be careful to protect their belongings.

d) What visitors might be at the door? Are Jonathan and his wife surprised?

Ans The visitors at the door are thieves who come at night to demand money. Jonathan and his wife feel frightened when they hear the loud knocking and threats. However, they are not completely surprised because robbery was common after the war. They know that many people are desperate and poor. So, although they are afraid, they accept it as part of the difficult situation in their country.

e) Why does no one respond? Why do the thieves call for the police?

Ans No one in the neighbourhood responds because they are afraid of getting into trouble. They do not want to risk their lives by helping Jonathan. Everyone thinks about their own safety first. The thieves call for the police in a mocking way. They know the police will not come or may not help properly. This shows that the law system is weak and people cannot depend on authorities.

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a) Why does ~~the~~ Jonathan mean by his expression "Nothing puzzles God"? What does this expression reveal about his character? Explain by citing details from the story?

Ans When Jonathan says, "Nothing Puzzles God," he means that God understands everything that happens in life. Humans may feel confused or worried, but God knows the reason behind every event. Jonathan believes that both good and bad things are part of God's plan. So, he does not question difficult situation.

This expression shows that Jonathan is a man of strong faith. Even after losing his

son and property in the war, he does not blame God. Instead, he remains thankful for the life of his family. He repeats this belief many times in the story.

It reveals that Jonathan is optimistic and hopeful. He accepts life calmly and trusts God completely. His faith helps him survive hardships without losing courage.

b) How does Jonathan change as he experiences the conflicts in his life? Explain.

Ans Jonathan faces many conflicts after the civil war. He loses one of his children and most of his property. Later, thieves rob him of his twenty pounds. These events could break a person's spirit.

However, Jonathan does not become bitter or hopeless. Instead, he stays positive and practical. After losing his money, he says that the money is "nothing" and life continues. He chooses to move forward rather than cry over loss.

His character shows strength and growth. He becomes even more determined to work hard and rebuild his life. Conflict does not change his faith or optimism. Instead, it makes him stronger and more focused on survival.

c) Read the extract and answer the questions below.

i) Who is the speaker

Ans. The speaker is Jonathan Iwegbu.

ii) Who is the speaker talking to?

Ans. He is talking to the thieves who have come to rob him at night.

iii) Who does 'they' refer to?

Ans. "They" refers to the government officials who gave him twenty pounds as relief money after the war.

d) Nigerian English has words like soja 'soldier' and katakata 'confusion', 'trouble' derived apparently from English words but transformed by native languages' phonologies. What does the author's use of dialect here add to the story?

Ans. The author uses Nigerian English words like "soja" and "katakata" to make the story realistic. These words show how people in Nigeria actually speak. It gives the story a local color and cultural identity.

The use of dialect makes characters feel natural and alive. Readers can better imagine their voices and environment. It also shows that English has mixed with local

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languages. Instead of using perfect British English, Achebe uses language that reflects Nigerian society. This shows the mix of English and native languages.

This technique adds authenticity to the story. It helps readers understand the social background and environment after the war. The dialect makes the story more powerful and meaningful because it represents real Nigerian life.

es Why do you think the thieves who come to rob Jonathan speak English with a heavier African accent than Jonathan does?

Ans The thieves speak English with a heavier African accent because they may be less educated than Jonathan. Jonathan seems more experienced and exposed to formal communication. He worked as a miner and later ran a small business, so his English is slightly clearer.

The difference in language also shows social class differences. The thieves appear rough, aggressive, and less refined. Their heavy accent makes them sound more threatening and dangerous. Jonathan's calmer speech shows his controlled and polite nature.

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Achebe uses this contrast to highlight character differences. It highlights class and education gaps in society. The speech style adds realism and depth to the story.

f) The title of the story "Civil Peace" itself is ironical as there is little to differentiate "civil peace" from "civil war". Do you think that the title of this story is appropriate, or would "civil war" have been a better title? Explain.

Ans. The title "Civil Peace" is ironic because life is not truly peaceful after the war ends. Although the fighting has stopped, people still face poverty, robbery, fear, and corruption. Jonathan is robbed even after peace is declared. In this way, peace does not feel very different from war.

However, the title is still appropriate. It shows that peace does not mean the end of suffering. Instead, it ~~means~~ means a new type of struggle. People must rebuild their lives and survive in difficult conditions.

Achebe wants to show that "civil peace" is imperfect but still important. Even with problems, people like Jonathan remain hopeful. Therefore, the title is meaningful and suitable for the story.

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a) How would you describe the civil peace in Nigeria?

Ans Civil peace in Nigeria, as shown in the story, is not completely peaceful. Although the civil war has officially ended. People still suffer from poverty, fear and crime. Many houses are destroyed, jobs are limited, and the government system is weak. Robbery and corruption are common. So, peace exists in name, but daily life is still full of struggle and uncertainty.

However, civil peace also brings hope and new beginnings. People like Jonathan try to rebuild their lives with courage and determination. Markets reopen, small businesses start again, and families try to live normally. There is no more gunfire or open fighting, which is a positive change.

Overall, civil peace in Nigeria is a time of recovery. It is imperfect and difficult, but it gives people a chance to restart life and look forward to a better future.